Research Statement

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I am a quantitative macroeconomist with a focus on labor markets, development, and inequality. My research examines how public policies and labor market institutions interact with household heterogeneity to shape aggregate outcomes and their distribution. My work combines reduced-form empirical evidence with heterogeneous-agent general equilibrium frameworks, disciplined by microeconomic data, and is organized around two strands. The first examines the equilibrium and unintended consequences of public policy, including agricultural price supports and input subsidies in India and alcohol prohibition in Bihar (India). The second studies gender inequality in labor and asset markets, its causes and its implications for the aggregate economy: how firm size shapes women's employment, how the slowdown in female labor supply contributed to jobless recoveries in the U.S., and how gender differences in income risk drive gaps in portfolio choice and wealth. My ongoing and future work extends both strands to study the impact of a rise in remote work post-COVID on gender and racial inequality.

Public Policy Evaluation

- **The Equilibrium Impact of Agricultural Support Prices and Input Subsidies** (with Anand Chopra and Lalit Contractor), *Reject-and-Resubmit*, *International Economic Review; STEG Small Research Grant, No. 1397*

  In this paper, we analyze the macroeconomic implications of two agricultural policies: (i) agricultural output price supports, under which governments procure a share of staple output at pre-announced prices and redistribute them as food rations and (ii) subsidies that lower the price of intermediate inputs faced by farmers. We use a dynamic general equilibrium model with heterogeneous agents, incomplete markets, and financial and mobility frictions to study the impact of these policies on occupational choices, intermediate input usage, and their resulting implications for consumer welfare and the agricultural productivity gap, defined as the ratio of non-agricultural to agricultural labor productivity. Calibrating the model to Indian data, this paper shows that while input and output price subsidies can raise agricultural productivity by encouraging input use, they impose a tax burden that disproportionately harms asset-poor households. As a result, removing either policy improves welfare, even as productivity indicators worsen. This work contributes to the macro-development literature by demonstrating a trade-off between promoting productivity and improving welfare in industrial policy design and by highlighting the importance of asset distributions and tax incidence in determining welfare outcomes.

- **Intoxicant Consumption Dynamics under Alcohol Prohibition: Evidence from India** (with Ronit Mukherji and Aparajita Dasgupta), *Submitted, Southern Economic Journal*

  In this paper, we study the impact of an alcohol prohibition policy, implemented in the state of Bihar (India) in 2016, on the consumption of other addictive substances. Using high-frequency panel data on household consumption, our empirical strategy exploits the variation in exposure to the Bihar ban in two complementary ways. We begin with an interstate dynamic difference-in-differences design that compares households in Bihar with households in neighboring states not subject to prohibition. We complement this analysis with a within-Bihar event-study design that compares households that did and did not consume alcohol before the ban. Together, the two designs allow us to distinguish the effect of the ban from confounding changes in market conditions, societal perceptions, and local supply factors that could affect households in Bihar. We find that alcohol spending falls sharply after prohibition. Among the treated households, spending on cigarettes, bidis, and tobacco also falls initially, but this decline later reverses as tobacco spending recovers over the medium run. This is consistent with complementarity between alcohol and tobacco consumption in the short run, but substitution between the two over time, when alcohol is unavailable. Our paper, therefore, underscores the importance of dynamic behavioral responses when evaluating public health policies.

Gender Inequality

- **Scaling Up to Decrease the Divide: Firm Size and Female Employment** (with Kanika Mahajan), *Revise-and-Resubmit, Journal of Human Resources*

  This paper examines how firm size and the job attributes firms offer shape employment opportunities for women. Using a wide range of data sources, which include firm- and individual-level datasets from India and the U.S., we document a robust positive relationship between firm size and relative female employment. Using a staggered difference-in-differences design to exploit state-level variation in labor law reforms in India that relaxed firm-size-based regulatory thresholds, we show that policies facilitating firm growth causally increase the share of female employees in firms. We then design a simple model of heterogeneous firms that hire both male and female workers to discuss channels through which firm size can impact relative female employment. We argue that larger, more productive firms are more likely to provide workplace amenities that are valued relatively more by women. These amenities raise women's productivity and willingness to work, helping explain the positive firm-size gradient in female employment. Consistent with this mechanism, we show empirically that larger firms are more likely to offer maternity benefits, childcare, work-from-home arrangements, employer-provided transport, and greater job stability, which are valued more by women.

Our paper provides the first comprehensive evaluation of the role of firm size distribution as a determinant of low female employment in developing economies. The findings demonstrate that policies not explicitly targeted at women can nonetheless reduce gender gaps by altering the distribution of firm sizes in the economy.

- **Female Labor Supply and Jobless Recovery**, *Working Paper*

  Female labor force participation in the U.S. rose steadily over the post-war era until the late 1980s; since then it has largely leveled off. Concurrent with this leveling off, since 1990, recessions in the U.S. have featured jobless recoveries. In this paper, I examine the extent to which the weakened trend contributes to slower recoveries and the demographic factors that resulted in this change. My empirical analysis shows that young, married women with children were the primary drivers of aggregate employment recoveries prior to 1990. These findings inform the development of a general equilibrium macroeconomic model that I use to study the interaction between female and male labor supply at the household and at the aggregate level. My model predicts that post-1990 aggregate employment recoveries were significantly slower than pre-1990 recoveries due to the weakened trend for young married women with children and is thus consistent with my empirical evidence both in the aggregate and in which individual groups show these changes. Decomposing the relative contributions of several underlying factors responsible for this pre-1990s rise, the model predicts that the narrowing gender wage gap is the most important factor in the overall increase. However, until the mid-1980s, when the upward trend in female labor supply was the strongest and recoveries in aggregate employment were brisk, a reduction in the number of young children for married women was the most crucial factor. With this insight, I use my framework to discuss policy implications for mitigating jobless recoveries. This paper is in preparation for submission to *Journal of Economic Dynamics and Control.*

- **Gender, Marriage, and Portfolio Choice: Role of Income Risk** (with Anand Chopra), *Working Paper (revised draft forthcoming)*

  In this paper, we examine the source of gender and marital status differences in portfolio choices among U.S. households. Specifically, we investigate the role of gender differences in income processes and quantify the importance of spousal insurance for their risk-taking behavior. Empirically, we document that single female-headed households invest a smaller share of their wealth in risky assets than single male-headed households, whereas married households hold a larger share. This same ranking holds for total wealth, with large gaps across the different groups. We also document that the variance of permanent income shocks for women is twice that of men, and men earn 43% more than women on average over the lifecycle. Income shocks across spouses are largely uncorrelated; thus, the potential of spousal insurance is high. To quantify the importance of these channels, we build an incomplete market lifecycle model with heterogeneous agents and multiple assets. We account for single

female, single male, and married households. We find that the gender wage gap matters early in a household's lifecycle, whereas higher income risk for women gains prominence later. This is because a lower income implies fewer resources at hand to enter the risky asset market, thus delaying participation for single households, particularly women. Higher income risk amplifies the precautionary saving motive, particularly as households age and the ratio of their expected future labor income to accumulated wealth falls, resulting in portfolio reallocation towards safe assets. We also show that the risky asset share of a single-earner married household is significantly lower than a dual-earner married household, consistent with the data. Thus, the presence of an additional earner increases the risk appetite of married households. The results illustrate how labor market inequality translates into long-run wealth inequality across different family structures, even absent differences in preferences.

Ongoing and future work: Remote Work and Inequality

In the next phase of my research agenda, I study the impact of a rise in remote work in the post-COVID era on labor allocations within households and on housing outcomes across racial groups. In the first project, on **"Working from home and Household Inequality"**, which is joint with Seonyoung Park, we study the aggregate welfare and distributional consequences of the post-COVID remote work expansion on female labor supply through spousal employment and within-household labor reallocation. Husbands' increased exposure to remote work lowers the effective cost of wives' labor force participation by relaxing child-care constraints, generating a cross-spousal labor supply spillover. Using microdata from the American Community Survey and a difference-in-differences design that exploits exogenous variation in occupational remote work feasibility, we document that wives whose husbands work from home are significantly more likely to be employed and to work longer hours. Next, using a heterogeneous-agent lifecycle model of household labor supply, we decompose the welfare and inequality effects of remote work expansion across the income distribution, distinguishing between within-household earnings gaps and between-household inequality arising from the concentration of remote work eligibility among high-skill, high-wage workers.

In the second project, on **"Remote work, Housing, and Racial Inequality"**, I explore the impact of an increase in remote work in the post-COVID era on housing decisions and quantify its effect on racial inequality in the U.S. I study how the rise of remote work interacts with housing price dynamics to differentially affect renters and homeowners across racial groups. Using a heterogeneous-agent model, I evaluate whether remote work as a job amenity mitigates or exacerbates racial disparities in housing affordability and labor market access. This work was supported by the Summer Research Apprenticeship Award at Bates College in 2025. These projects reinforce my broader research agenda on how labor market institutions and policies interact with household decisions and jointly shape inequality.